

Aquanaut

The Webelos Swimming Adventure



Rank: Webelos (4th grade) | **Type:** Elective adventure | **Time:** 2 meetings (1 dry-land + 1 swim day)

Den leader: _____ **Dates:** _____

What's in this guide

1. Adventure at a glance
2. Before you start: safety & planning
3. Meeting plans
4. Requirement-by-requirement teaching notes
5. Extra games & activities
6. Den tracking sheet
7. Answer keys

Companion files in this folder: **Scout-Handouts.pdf** (one double-sided sheet per scout) and **Parent-Letter.pdf** (send home before swim day).

The big idea

Aquanaut teaches Webelos that **water is fun when we're smart about it**. By the end, every scout should be able to tell you the safety rules we follow before anyone gets wet, how to help a struggling swimmer *without* becoming a second victim, how to spot and stop getting dangerously cold, and should have tried the same swim test used across Scouting America.

Goals for your scouts

- **Know the rules:** Explain, in their own words, why we use Safe Swim Defense, ability groups, and the buddy system.
- **Help safely:** Know the order of rescue (Reach, Throw, Row, Go) and that a Cub Scout's job is to **Reach or Throw — but Don't Go**.
- **Stay warm:** Recognize the warning signs of hypothermia (shivering and "the Umbles") and know what to do.
- **Try their best:** Attempt treading water and the swimmer test — the requirement is to *attempt*, so effort earns it.
- **Practice it for real:** Use the buddy system and ability groups during at least 30 minutes of free swim.

The requirements

#	Requirement (summary)	When we do it
1	State the safety precautions you need to take before doing any swimming activity.	Meeting 1
2	Explain the meaning of "order of rescue" and demonstrate the reach and throw rescue techniques from land.	Meeting 1
3	Learn how to prevent and treat hypothermia.	Meeting 1 (review on swim day)
4	Attempt to tread water.	Swim day
5	Attempt the Scouting America (BSA) swimmer test.	Swim day
6	Have 30 minutes or more of free swim time where you practice the buddy system and stay within your ability group. Qualified adult supervision conducts at least three buddy checks per half hour.	Swim day

Other ways a scout can earn Aquanaut

Per the Webelos handbook, a scout may also earn this adventure by **passing the BSA swimmer test** or by **taking swimming lessons from a qualified instructor** (e.g., a Red Cross or YMCA program). If a scout already qualifies, still invite them to every activity — strong swimmers make great "safety assistants" for the dry-land stations.

Always confirm requirement wording against the current Webelos Handbook or Scouting America's online adventure page; requirements are summarized here for planning.

Supplies checklist

- | | |
|---|---|
| ☐ Printed Scout Handout (1 double-sided sheet per scout) | ☐ Bucket or tub of ice water + paper towels |
| ☐ Parent Letter (1 per family) | ☐ Coins, marbles, or LEGO bricks; a button-up shirt |
| ☐ 2–3 pool noodles or a broom / long pole | ☐ Index cards with the 8 Safe Swim Defense points (see Requirement 1) |
| ☐ Beach towel or old shirt | ☐ Buddy tags / buddy board and colored bands for ability groups (swim day) |
| ☐ Rope (25–30 ft) tied to an empty gallon jug with a little water in it (or a real throw ring / throw bag) | ☐ Whistle |
| ☐ Hula hoop or tarp to be "the water" | ☐ Pencils, den tracking sheet |

Safety & planning for adults

SAFETY FIRST

Every Scouting swim activity follows Safe Swim Defense. The adult in charge of the swim must have current **Safe Swim Defense training** (free online at my.scouting.org). Plan swim day at a pool or waterfront with **trained lifeguards on duty**, and check with the facility about how they handle Scouting swim tests.

Planning timeline

When	To-do
4–6 weeks out	Reserve pool time (ask for a lane or roped-off area with shallow and deep water). Ask the facility or your council who can administer the BSA swimmer test there. Confirm the adult in charge has current Safe Swim Defense training.
3 weeks out	Send home the Parent Letter . Collect Annual Health and Medical Record (Parts A & B) for every scout and adult getting in the water — this covers the "personal health review" point of Safe Swim Defense.
1–2 weeks out	Hold Meeting 1 (dry land: requirements 1–3). Recruit adult volunteers: a lookout, a buddy-board keeper, and parents willing to be "in-water" helpers if the facility allows.
Swim day	Health check at arrival, assign buddies, swim tests, treading water, 30+ minutes free swim with buddy checks (requirements 4–6).
After	Record completions in Scoutbook; recognize the adventure loop at the next pack meeting.

Ability groups (what the swim test decides)

Group	How they qualify	Where they swim
Nonswimmer	Has not yet passed the beginner or swimmer test.	Shallow water, no more than about waist deep.
Beginner	Jumps feet first into water over their head, levels off, swims 25 feet on the surface, stops, turns sharply, resumes swimming, and returns to the start.	Water just over their head, next to the shallow area.
Swimmer	Passes the full swimmer test (see requirement 5).	Deep-water swimmer area.

Swim classifications are typically renewed each year. The facility sets exact area boundaries — follow their lifeguards.

Keep it positive

Some 4th graders are nervous about water or embarrassed that they can't swim yet. Say it plainly and often: **"Every requirement that says 'attempt' is about trying. Doing your best earns it."** Never announce test results to the group, never rank scouts, and never pressure a scout into deeper water. A nonswimmer who puts their face in the water for the first time had a huge win — celebrate it like one.

Youth protection reminders for swim day

- Two registered adults present at all times; no one-on-one contact.
- Appropriate swimwear for everyone. Changing areas: adults and youth change separately; adults do not change or shower with youth.
- Photos: only with families' permission and never in changing areas.

Meeting 1 — "Dry-Land Training" (about 60 min)

Location: regular den meeting spot. Covers requirements 1, 2, and 3.

Time	Segment	What happens
10 min	Gathering	Water Safety True or False (statements in the Answer Keys section): one side of the room is "True," the other "False." Read a statement; scouts run to their answer. Don't correct yet — say "Hold that thought, we'll find out tonight!"
5 min	Opening	Flag ceremony, Scout Oath and Scout Law. Introduce: "Tonight you're training to be Aquanauts."
15 min	Req. 1	Teach Safe Swim Defense with the memory trick, then play Safe Swim Scramble and a Buddy Check Drill .
15 min	Req. 2	Order of rescue talk, then Reach & Throw Stations — every scout demonstrates both.
10 min	Req. 3	Ice Water Fumble Challenge and Umbles Charades .
5 min	Closing	Revisit the True/False statements they missed. Cubmaster's Minute (end of Requirement 6 section). Hand out Scout Handouts and the Parent Letter.

Meeting 2 — "Swim Day" (about 90 min at the pool)

Covers requirements 4, 5, and 6. Review requirement 3 when scouts get out.

Time	Segment	What happens
10 min	Arrival & check-in	Confirm health forms. Quick health check: "Anyone feeling sick or have anything the adults should know?" Assign buddies (similar ability). Go over the rules: walk on deck, listen for the whistle, stay in your area.
5 min	Safety huddle	Scouts recite the 8 Safe Swim Defense points using the memory trick. Practice one dry buddy check on deck.
25–30 min	Req. 5	Swim tests, run by the qualified test administrator. Scouts waiting sit with their buddy. Give each scout their ability-group band as they finish.
10 min	Req. 4	Treading water, in each scout's ability area (swimmers in deep water; others hold the wall or use water just over their heads with a lifeguard's OK).
30+ min	Req. 6	Free swim with buddy checks at least every 10 minutes (3+ per half hour). Mix in the pool games from the Extra Games section.
5–10 min	Towel off & close	Towels on, dry layers, snack. Ask: "Who's shivering? What does that mean? What do we do?" (Req. 3 review.) Cheer for everyone's effort.

1

REQUIREMENT 1

State the safety precautions you need to take before doing any swimming activity.

Goal: Scouts can name the safety steps Scouting uses for every swim (Safe Swim Defense), and can explain *why* the buddy system and ability groups matter.

SAY IT LIKE THIS

"Swimming is one of the most fun things we do in Scouting. But water is also one of the few places where something can go wrong *fast* and *quietly* — a person who is drowning usually can't yell or wave. So Scouting has a plan we use every single time we swim. It's called **Safe Swim Defense**, and it has 8 parts. Here's a silly sentence to help you remember them:"

Quick Pups Swim Rapidly, Lazy Alligators Bask Daily.

	Safe Swim Defense point	What it means (kid version)
Q	Qualified Supervision	A trained adult is in charge of the swim.
P	Personal Health Review	Adults know about your health. Tell them if you feel sick or have a health issue.
S	Safe Area	The swim area has been checked: we know how deep it is, and there's nothing dangerous in it.
R	Response Personnel (Lifeguards)	Trained lifeguards are there and ready to help.
L	Lookout	Someone watches the whole area from a spot where they can see everybody.
A	Ability Groups	You swim only where your swim test says you can: nonswimmer, beginner, or swimmer area.
B	Buddy System	Never swim alone. Stay with your buddy the whole time and answer every buddy check.
D	Discipline	Follow the rules and the lifeguard's directions. No running, pushing, or dunking.

SAY IT LIKE THIS

Why buddies? "Your buddy is your personal lifeguard and you are theirs. You stay close enough to reach each other. When the adult calls '**Buddy check!**' you grab your buddy's hand, raise it high, and freeze and stay quiet so the adults can count. If someone's buddy is missing, the adults find out in seconds, not minutes."

ACTIVITY

Safe Swim Scramble (8 min). Write each of the 8 points on an index card, with the kid-version meaning on a second card (16 cards). Shuffle and hand them out. Scouts find their match, then line up in "Quick Pups" order and each pair reads their card aloud.

Buddy Check Drill (5 min). Pair scouts up. Let them move around the room ("swimming"). Blow the whistle or call "Buddy check!" — pairs grab hands, raise them, and freeze. Time them; try to beat the den's record. Secretly send one scout to hide behind a door on one round and ask: "What should happen right now?" (Everyone stops; adults search immediately.)

CHECK FOR UNDERSTANDING

- What do you do when you hear "Buddy check"? (Grab buddy's hand, raise it, stay still and quiet.)
- Why can't a beginner swim in the deep end just because a lifeguard is watching? (Ability groups keep you in water you've proven you can handle.)
- Name 3 things that have to happen before anyone gets in the water.

2

REQUIREMENT 2

Explain the meaning of "order of rescue" and demonstrate the reach and throw rescue techniques from land.

Goal: Scouts can list the order of rescue, understand that it goes from safest to riskiest, and can show a reach and a throw rescue from land. Most importantly: **Cub Scouts never swim out to rescue someone.**

SAY IT LIKE THIS

"Here's a scary fact: lots of people who drown were trying to rescue someone else. A scared person in the water will grab anything — including you — and pull you under. So rescuers follow an order, starting with the safest way to help:"

1. **REACH** — Lie down on the deck or dock and reach out with a pole, noodle, towel, or even your arm or leg. Stay low so you don't get pulled in.
2. **THROW** — If they're too far to reach, throw something that floats: a ring buoy, a throw rope, a life jacket, even a cooler or jug. Hang on to the end of the rope!
3. **ROW** — A trained adult can use a boat to get to them.
4. **GO** — Only a trained lifeguard swims out, and they bring something that floats.

"Your rule as a Webelos is: **Yell for help, then Reach or Throw — but Don't Go!**"

How to do it right

Reach

- Shout for an adult/lifeguard first.
- Get **low**: lie flat or kneel, or hold onto something solid (ladder, railing, a friend holding your legs).
- Extend the object; say "Grab on!"
- Pull them slowly to the edge.
- If you feel yourself being pulled in, **let go**.

Throw

- Shout for help first.
- Hold the end of the rope or step on it.
- Yell "Rope!" so they're ready.
- Throw **past** the person so the rope lands across them — not at their head.
- Crouch low and pull in slowly, hand over hand.

ACTIVITY

Reach & Throw Stations (15 min). Lay a hula hoop or tarp on the floor about 8 ft away — that's "the water." A volunteer (adult or scout) sits in it as the "swimmer" and acts panicked.

- **Station A – Reach:** Scout yells "Help! Lifeguard!", lies down on the "deck," reaches out with a pool noodle or towel, and pulls the swimmer in. Swap roles.
- **Station B – Throw:** Scout holds the rope end, yells "Rope!", and throws the jug so the rope lands across the swimmer. Pull in. Move the hoop farther away each round for a challenge.
- **Bonus – Look around:** Scatter objects (backpack, jacket, water bottle, ball, pillow) and ask "Which of these could you use to reach? To throw?"

Sign off requirement 2 when each scout explains the order and completes one reach and one throw.

CHECK FOR UNDERSTANDING

- Why is "Reach" first and "Go" last? (Reach is safest for the rescuer; going in the water is the most dangerous.)
- Why do you lie down to do a reach? (So you don't get pulled in.)
- What's the very first thing to do? (Shout for an adult or lifeguard.)

3

REQUIREMENT 3

Learn how to prevent and treat hypothermia.

Goal: Scouts know what hypothermia is, can name the early warning signs, and know how to prevent it and what to do if a buddy is getting too cold.

SAY IT LIKE THIS

"**Hypothermia** (hi-po-THER-mee-uh) means your body is losing heat faster than it can make it, and your insides start getting too cold. Water pulls heat out of you about **25 times faster than air** does, so you can get hypothermia even on a warm day if you stay in the water too long or sit around wet in the wind."

"The first sign is **shivering** — that's your body's alarm bell. If it keeps going, watch for the **Umbles**:"

- **Stumbles** – clumsy, tripping
- **Fumbles** – fingers don't work right
- **Mumbles** – hard to talk clearly
- **Grumbles** – cranky, confused

"Also look for blue or purple lips and fingers. People with hypothermia often don't notice it themselves — that's why **buddies watch each other**."

Prevent it

- Get out of the water when you start shivering.
- Towel off right away and put on dry clothes or a sweatshirt.
- Stay out of the wind; wear a hat when it's cool.
- Eat snacks and drink water — food is fuel for body heat.
- Take breaks; don't stay in cold water a long time.

Treat it

- **Tell an adult right away.**
- Get out of the water and out of the wind.
- Take off wet clothes; put on dry, warm layers or a blanket.
- If they're awake and alert: a warm (not hot) drink and a snack.
- Stumbling, confused, or very sleepy? That's serious — adults call 911.

ACTIVITY

Ice Water Fumble Challenge (6 min). Each scout first times how fast they can pick up 10 coins (or button 3 buttons on a shirt). Then they hold one hand in ice water for **30 seconds** and try again with that hand. Talk about it: "Why was it harder? Imagine your whole body feeling like that." Keep it short, make it optional, and dry hands afterward.

Umbles Charades (4 min). Scouts draw a card — Stumbles, Mumbles, Fumbles, Grumbles, Shivering — and act it out. The den guesses, then shouts what to do: "Tell an adult! Get dry! Get warm!"

CHECK FOR UNDERSTANDING

- What is the first warning sign that you're getting too cold? (Shivering.)
- Name two of the Umbles.
- Your buddy's lips are blue and they're mumbling. What do you do? (Tell an adult, get them out of the water, dry and warm.)

4

REQUIREMENT 4

Attempt to tread water.

Goal: Scouts try to stay upright with their head above water using slow, steady arm and leg movements. It's a key survival skill: if you fall in, treading water lets you stay up, breathe, and call for help.

SAY IT LIKE THIS

"Treading water is like standing up in water that's too deep to stand in. The secret is **slow and relaxed**. Panicking and splashing wears you out fast."

- **Arms – "spread the peanut butter":** Hands flat, just under the surface, sweep them out and in, like spreading peanut butter on a giant slice of bread.
- **Legs – pick one:** *Bicycle* (pedal slowly), *scissor* (one leg forward, one back, snap together), or *frog kick* (knees out, kick around and together).
- **Body:** Stay tall, chin at the water, breathe slow. Look at a friend on the deck and smile!

ACTIVITY

Tread & Talk. In each ability area (with the lifeguard's OK), scouts tread while answering easy questions called by a leader: "Favorite pizza topping? What's the Cub Scout motto?" Talking keeps them calm. Build up: 15 sec → 30 sec → 1 minute. Nonswimmers can hold the wall with one hand and practice the arms and legs — that's a real attempt.

5

REQUIREMENT 5

Attempt the Scouting America (BSA) swimmer test.

Goal: Every scout tries the test in a supportive, low-pressure setting, and learns which ability group they're in and what to practice next.

The swimmer test

1. Jump feet first into water over your head.
2. Level off and swim **75 yards** in a strong manner using one or more of: sidestroke, breaststroke, trudgen, or crawl.
3. Then swim **25 yards** using an easy, resting backstroke.
4. The 100 yards must be one continuous swim with **no stops** and include **at least one sharp turn**.
5. After the swim, rest by **floating**.

SAY IT LIKE THIS

"This is the same test Scouts BSA and even adults take to swim in the deep area. It's long — 100 yards is four lengths of most pools. The requirement says **attempt**, so if you give it your best try, you've earned this part no matter how far you get. Whatever group you're in today, you'll know exactly what to practice to move up."

SAFETY FIRST

The test must be given by a qualified person (for example, the facility's lifeguard/aquatics staff or a council-approved test administrator) with lifeguards watching. **The test administrator decides how each scout attempts it safely** — a scout who isn't comfortable in deep water may start with the beginner test. Record each scout's result (Swimmer / Beginner / Nonswimmer) and the date.

6

REQUIREMENT 6

Have 30 minutes, or more, of free swim time where you practice the buddy system and stay within your ability group. The qualified adult supervision should conduct at least three buddy checks per half hour of swimming.

Goal: Scouts use everything they learned, for real, while having fun. This is the "reward" — but the adults are watching for buddy habits.

SAY IT LIKE THIS

"Now it's time to show you're real Aquanauts. You and your buddy stay together, stay in your area, and when you hear the whistle and 'Buddy check!' — hands up, freeze, quiet. We'll do at least three of these. Let's see if our den can be the fastest buddy check at the pool!"

Running a buddy check

1. Blow one long whistle blast and call "**Buddy check!**"
2. Buddies grab hands, raise them high, and stay still and quiet.
3. The adult counts pairs and compares to the buddy board (the count must match the number checked in).
4. If anyone is missing: everyone out of the water, lifeguards notified, search immediately.
5. Call "All clear" and resume swimming.

Tip: Set a phone timer for every 10 minutes so you get 3+ checks per half hour. Write the check times below as proof of the requirement.

Buddy check	Time	All accounted for?
#1		
#2		
#3		
#4		

Extra games & activities

ACTIVITY

Buddy Check Challenge (pool): Surprise buddy checks become a competition — fastest pair to get hands up and freeze earns a point for the den.

Treasure Dive (pool): Toss sinking rings or diving sticks into each ability area. Buddies take turns retrieving them. Keep items in water appropriate for each group.

Noodle Relay (pool, shallow): Buddies push a pool noodle across the area and back — no hands allowed, only blowing on it or nudging with noses/chins.

Float Contest (pool): Who can float on their back the longest while perfectly still? (Great practice for the end of the swimmer test.)

Rescue Relay (dry land, extra meeting time): Teams race to pick the right rescue object from a pile and complete a reach, then a throw, to "swimmers" in hula hoops.

Cubmaster's Minute: "Who's got your back?"

"At the pool, your buddy keeps you safe. But the buddy system doesn't stop at the water. At school, on the bus, on the playground — a good buddy notices when you're having a hard time and gets help. A good buddy doesn't let you do something dangerous. The Scout Law says a Scout is *helpful* and *friendly*. This week, be the kind of buddy you'd want in the water with you: someone who's always watching out for their friends."

Den tracking sheet

Write the date completed in each box. Use the last column to record swim test result: S = Swimmer, B = Beginner, N = Nonswimmer. Mark "Alt" if earned by passing the swimmer test or completing swim lessons.

Scout	1 Safety	2 Rescue	3 Hypothermia	4 Tread	5 Swim test	6 Free swim	Result S/B/N	Alt?

Swim day buddy board

Buddy pair	Scout A	Scout B	Ability area	Checked in	Checked out
1					
2					
3					
4					
5					
6					

Gathering game: Water Safety True or False

#	Statement	Answer	Why
1	You should always swim with a buddy.	TRUE	Buddies watch each other and get help fast.
2	If someone is in trouble, jump in and save them.	FALSE	Yell for help, then Reach or Throw — Don't Go.
3	You can get dangerously cold even in the summer.	TRUE	Water pulls heat from your body much faster than air.
4	If a lifeguard is watching, anyone can swim in the deep end.	FALSE	Stay in your ability group's area.
5	Shivering is your body's warning that you're getting too cold.	TRUE	Get out, dry off, warm up.
6	If there's a lifeguard, you don't need a buddy.	FALSE	Lifeguards <i>and</i> buddies — both are part of Safe Swim Defense.
7	A pool noodle, towel, or shirt can be used to reach someone.	TRUE	Anything long and grabbable works for a reach.
8	Running on the pool deck is OK if you're careful.	FALSE	Wet decks are slippery. Walk!
9	Tell an adult if you don't feel well before you swim.	TRUE	That's the Personal Health Review.
10	Throw a rescue rope right at the person's head.	FALSE	Throw past them so the rope lands across them.

Handout word search key

B	S	H	I	V	E	R	I	R	B
O	L	I	F	E	G	U	A	R	D
H	I	F	L	O	A	T	C	B	G
T	R	E	A	D	Y	K	T	I	D
B	U	D	D	Y	T	W	H	U	H
D	N	B	D	B	B	A	R	P	L
S	P	L	A	S	H	A	O	W	T
K	R	E	A	C	H	C	W	I	W
M	L	S	W	I	M	S	A	F	E
K	I	O	H	B	N	L	C	R	O